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Do coworking spaces trump dedicated offices for start-ups?



Coworking spaces offer interesting possibilities for startups – both good and bad.

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“A

coworking space is more than just an office space”, says Chaitanya Kumar, the manager at 91spring-

board, a blooming coworking space based in Mumbai. In just a little over a decade, coworking spaces have transpired to become a phenomenon that has revolutionised the way millions of people work. Investors are pouring in ridiculous amounts of funds to get their feet firmly planted into this growing space. Indian coworking space provider, Awfis recently announced that they raised \$20 million (approximately ₹128 crores) in a single funding round from Sequoia Capital India. Reportedly, this is the highest amount any company has received in a single funding round in this specific startup segment.

What was once seen rigidly as a freelancer's domain, is now being explored by startups and businesses of all sizes and prominence. According to a report named Coworking: The Office of the Future, real estate expenses takes 9-12 per cent of overall operating costs for a well-established corporate. The expense could very easily be even higher for startups. Coworking spaces offer flexibility, cost reduction and save precious time for startups that usually are better off without the added nuisance of having to figure out all the externalities.

WHY ARE COWORKING SPACES IMPORTANT

The increasing popularity of coworking spaces has brought in companies and individuals of all sizes and demographics. This is mainly since coworking spaces have received sufficient publicity and people now have a better understanding of what they

offer. For instance, startup companies benefit from the experience of veteran companies also in the space. Trios, a coworking space in Pune, hosts established companies like Microsoft along with famed startups like OLX and Dunzo. On the other hand, there could be some disadvantages too. Let's have a look at both angles in detail.

ADVANTAGES OF COWORKING SPACES FOR STARTUPS

Flexibility

Coworking spaces host flexible plan options, where the time period you can stay at a coworking space is not pre-determined, unlike dedicated offices which are usually leased for at least a year. Coworking spaces allow companies to lease spaces on a yearly, monthly and even daily basis. Individual professionals that need to meet with clients occasionally can rent a coworking space on a daily basis, which comes up to around ₹300 per person per day.

Cost flexibility and overall reduction for startups is also an enticing factor. Divya Karnad, the community manager at Trios, Pune said, “There is almost a 35 per cent cost reduction at Trios compared to dedicated office spaces. Where a company would have to pay over ₹12,000 per person each month, here that cost would shrink down to ₹7,500.” Coworking spaces have no upfront fees, no deposits and host a wide variety of plans often tailor-made for the startup. However, in startups that house more than 10 employees, the cost reduction is not that steep. Maulik Bengali, CTO and founder of Ajackus, based at 91springboard, Mumbai, stated, “There definitely isn't any cost reduction after